

succeeded in turning their enemies back, though several thousand more names were added to the casualty rolls. Lee desperately struggled to keep his remaining supply line, the South Side Railroad, from being severed.

38 The number of Black regiments at the siege of Petersburg. Secretary of War Edwin Stanton stated, "The hardest fighting was done by the Black troops."

Dark winter days

As winter set in, Lee faced another worry: desertion. Union pickets knew that "Johnnie Reb" (the archetypal Southerner) was waiting for the results of the presidential election in the North. After Lincoln prevailed, hope went out of the Army of Northern Virginia. Each day for months on end, the incessant shelling continued. Nerves were breaking. Self-inflicted gunshot wounds, and occasional suicides, were reported. At night, scores of men disappeared, some coming into the Union lines to surrender. A truce was called at Christmas, and soldiers emerged from the trenches without fear of snipers. Robert E. Lee's winter of discontent was upon him, and the prospects for spring looked bleak.